

improvisation amazed everyone present, and the position was his. By this time, he was an experienced church composer of psalm settings, hymns, choral motets, and a complete Requiem Mass, mostly written for St. Florian. Although accomplished, these works conform to conservative local church-music tradition, and show little sign of the strikingly individual mastery that was to come.

Musical life in Linz was much more wide-ranging than at St. Florian, and Bruckner now found himself encountering the concert-hall works of Beethoven and the other Classical masters. Deeply impressed and intimidated by Beethoven's music in particular, he enrolled in a musical correspondence course run by Simon Sechter in Vienna (see [box](#)), and worked on its various technical exercises so obsessively that Sechter warned him to slow down or risk mental problems. Two years after completing the course, Bruckner heard Wagner's music for the first time: a performance of *Tannhäuser* triggered a near-idolatrous admiration of the older composer and a search to find a way of responding to Wagner's advanced harmonic language within Bruckner's own style. The result, in 1864, was what he regarded as his first "official" piece, a choral and orchestral Mass in D minor, to be followed by two more in E minor and F minor.

Bruckner's eccentric streak had not been modified by years of professional life in Linz. He continued to engage with the world around him in the style of an Austrian countryman, retaining his rural accent and dialect. His desire to marry led him to propose to a sequence of teenage girls—thanks to a simple conviction that for marriage to be worthy in the eyes of God, his prospective